

RANJAN RAHI



HAPPINESS MANTRA

"The Ganga water that has reached your households can be used for drinking, bathing, cooking... It will also help in irrigation by raising the water table"

NITISH KUMAR

Chief Minister, Bihar, while launching the project

infrastructure was a whole new ball game. In fact, the water pipelines had to encounter a total of 29 road crossings, 28 river, stream and big drain crossings, 11 oil pipeline crossings and seven railway crossings. So, while the engineers were involved in drawing a model to negotiate all these infrastructural and topographical challenges, the bureaucrats, in addition to monitoring the project's progress, had to reach out to several central agencies for their no-objection clearances.

But the water resources department remained focused on the job at hand. And finally, an idea that initially seemed to be out of reach saw the light of day, when Nitish Kumar launched the Rs 4,000 crore Ganga Water Supply Scheme, or the Gangajal Aapurti Yojana, in late November last year. "The Ganga water which has reached your household will not only be used for drinking but also bathing, cooking and other purposes... It will also help in meeting irrigation requirements by improving the groundwater level in these districts," the CM announced during the project launch in Rajgir, according to local media reports.

These are still early days. As of now, nearly 100,000 houses in Rajgir, Gaya and Bodh Gaya, or half a million of population, are being provided treated Ganga water through taps in their houses. On average, each individual is getting about 135 litres of water daily for drinking and domestic use. Another water treatment plant being built in Nawada, 25 kilometres southeast of Rajgir, will purify 36 million litres of water daily for supply to the Nawada township. It should become operational by the year-end, say department officials.

If the idea—of turning the devastating floodwater into a boon for Bihar's parched regions—is ingenious, its execution is an example of engineering excellence. It involves moving millions of litres of water from Hathidah, situated on the banks of the Ganga in Patna district, through an intricate network of both underground and above-ground steel pipelines, running as high as 123 metres above mean sea level at Jethian Hills near Gaya. First, the water is shifted to a detention centre at Motnaje in Nawada (to minimise friction and transit loss), from where it is further transported to three large reservoirs—two in Gaya and one in Rajgir, with the farthest located over 150 km from Hathidah—before being treated and supplied to various households via an additional network of pipelines, treatment plants and supply stations.

As of now, the project's capacity is adequate to cater to the projected population till 2051. But, the network is being expanded further to reach other parts of Gaya, Nalanda and Nawada districts. More importantly, officials say, the project will act as a model to replicate and supply floodwater from Ganga and its tributaries to other water-starved areas of the state. ■